

BOOK ONE OF
THE EMBER THRONE SAGA

REALMS

PEOPLE

DECRETS

*Stories
Shape
Realms.*

*Some
Legends
Never
Die.*

THE
SEVEN
PROVINCES

DUSKHAVEN

MAREN

THE
FROZEN
WILDS

THE CROWN OF EMBERS

A NOVEL

JANVI THAKRE

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THE CROWN OF EMBERS

A NOVEL

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*For everyone who ever finished a story
and immediately wanted to know what happened next.*

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HOUSE VOSS
STEADY THE REALM



I.

The physicians had stopped lying to King Aldric Voss weeks ago. Now they simply bowed, murmured that the tonics were “taking hold,” and hurried from the royal bedchamber before their faces could betray them, out into a corridor that reeked faintly of vinegar, tallow smoke, and the particular sweetness that comes just before rot.

Aldric had ruled the Seven Provinces of Maren for thirty-one years. He had buried two wives, outlived three wars, and built the aqueduct that still carried clean water into every quarter of Duskhaven, including the poorest. None of that mattered now. What mattered now was the wet, tearing sound in his chest each time he breathed, and the black lines creeping up the veins of his left arm like ink spilled into water.

He was sixty-one years old, and he was dying by inches, and everyone in the palace knew it except, officially, the palace itself.

In the antechamber outside, Lord Halden Maddox waited with the patience of a man who had learned long ago that patience, properly deployed, was worth more than any army. He was fifty, silver-templed, dressed with the understated richness of a man who did not need to prove his wealth because everyone already owed him some portion of it. As Master of Coin, he held the ledgers of half the noble houses in Maren — their debts, their harvests, their hidden shortfalls — and a man who holds another man’s ledgers holds a leash, whether or not the other man feels it yet.

The king’s physician, an elderly woman named Maester Yrsa, emerged looking gray.

“How long,” Maddox asked, not quite a question.

“Weeks.” Yrsa did not meet his eyes. “Perhaps less, my lord. The rot has reached his heart.”

“Does he know?”

“He has known longer than any of us. He simply hasn’t said it aloud, because saying it aloud makes it a fact the court must act on, and he doesn’t trust the court to act on it wisely.”



Maddox almost smiled at that. It was, unfortunately, an entirely accurate assessment of the court, Maddox included.

He waited until the physician had gone before allowing himself the small, private luxury of standing still in the empty corridor and simply thinking. Prince Corwin — soon to be King Corwin, first of his name, if the gods and the physicians agreed on a timeline — was twenty-two years old, fond of wine, fonder of flattery, and had never in his life balanced a household budget, let alone a kingdom's treasury. He would need guidance. He would, in fact, need Maddox for every decision of consequence he would ever make, and Maddox intended to ensure that need never faded.

There was only one obstacle Maddox could presently identify, and that obstacle was six hundred miles north, sitting in a cold stone keep, entirely unaware that his old friendship with a dying king was about to become the most dangerous thing he owned.

— II. —

The raven reached Wintermoor on a morning so cold the courtyard well had frozen solid overnight, and Lord Edran Thorne read it twice before he said a word to anyone.

By order of His Grace King Aldric Voss: Lord Edran Thorne is summoned to Duskhaven with all haste, and is bidden to bring his eldest son. No further explanation is given, nor is one required.

It was sealed with the crown's own wax, not Maddox's green sigil, which told Edran two things at once: first, that the summons genuinely came from Aldric and not from some scheme dressed in the king's name, and second, that whatever Aldric wanted, he wanted it badly enough to spend his failing strength dictating it personally rather than letting a steward handle the correspondence.

Edran Thorne was forty-four, broad through the shoulders in the way of a man who had spent his youth on horseback rather than at court, with a beard gone iron-gray at the jaw and eyes that missed very little. House Thorne had held Wintermoor and the northern marches for eleven generations, sworn to guard the Greywall and the cold country beyond it, and in all that time the Thornes had earned a single, simple reputation: they did not lie, they did not break oaths, and they did not forgive men who did either.

It was, his late wife had once told him fondly, both his greatest virtue and the trait most likely to get him killed.

He found his daughter in the solar, curled into the window seat with a book of old borderland histories she had already read twice, her dark hair escaping its braid the way it always did by midmorning. Lyra Thorne was sixteen, sharp-boned and sharper-tongued, and possessed of the particular kind of intelligence that made grown men uncomfortable because it so rarely announced itself before it was too late to guard against.

"You're leaving," she said, before he'd spoken a word, watching him fold the letter into his coat.

"I'm summoned."

"By the king, or by whoever's standing closest to the king's ear these days." She set the book down.

“Which is it?”

“The seal is genuine.”

“That’s not what I asked, Father.”

Edran allowed himself a small, tired smile — the one he reserved only for her, because she was the only one of his children who reliably earned it. “No,” he admitted. “It isn’t.”

He told her what he suspected: that Aldric was dying, that Corwin was unready, and that Maddox — whom Edran had met exactly four times in twenty years and trusted on none of those occasions — was very likely the man actually holding the reins of a kingdom about to lose its rider.

“Then don’t go,” Lyra said, with the particular bluntness of someone who has not yet learned, or has simply refused to learn, that some things cannot be avoided by force of will alone. “Send Kael. Send anyone. You said yourself Maddox doesn’t summon men he needs — he summons men he wants close enough to watch drown.”

“I did say that.” Edran crossed to the window, looking out over Wintermoor’s frost-white yard, where his soldiers drilled in the thin morning light, breath steaming. “Which is precisely why I have to go myself, and not send someone in my place. Aldric is my king and, gods help me, still something like my friend. If he’s dying and calling for me by name, it’s because he needs a man he trusts standing near his son when he goes, and there is no one else in this kingdom who fits that description less conveniently for House Maddox than me.”

“That’s not a reason to walk into a trap. That’s a reason someone built the trap around you specifically.”

“Maybe.” He turned back to her, and for a moment the mask of the dutiful lord slipped, and she saw something rawer underneath — not fear, exactly, but its close and more useful cousin, caution. “Which is why you’re not coming, and why Wren stays here under guard, and why I want you watching everything that moves through this castle while I’m gone. Every raven. Every merchant. Every stranger who stops at the village inn for longer than a night. You have better instincts than half my council, Lyra, and I would rather leave the north in your hands than in theirs.”

It was, though he did not fully realize it in the moment, the single wisest decision Edran Thorne would make in the whole of that final year of his life.

III.

That night, deep beyond the Greywall, in the frozen country the old maps still called the Hollow Marches, a border patrol of four watchmen found what they would later describe, in reports nobody in Duskhaven bothered to read, as “wrong snow.”

It lay in a shallow crater half a mile past the last watch cairn — snow that had not fallen so much as *settled*, packed unnaturally flat in a perfect circle thirty feet across, at the center of which the eldest of the four watchmen, a weathered veteran named Corbin Hale, found a dead man he did not recognize, lying on his back with his eyes open and frost-white, his throat entirely unmarked, and his

hands folded neatly across his chest as though someone — or something — had arranged him there with care.

“He’s not one of ours,” said the youngest of the patrol, a boy of seventeen named Petyr, crouching close enough that his breath fogged over the corpse’s open eyes. “Not one of the Marcher clans either. Look at the boots. That’s southern leather.”

“Doesn’t matter whose he is,” Corbin said. “Matters why there’s not a mark on him and why the snow around him’s packed like a hundred men stood here in a circle and not one of them left a footprint walking away.”

They burned the body, as the old regulations required for anything found dead and unmarked in the Hollow Marches — regulations so old that most of the current watch had assumed, until that night, that they were superstition rather than procedure — and Corbin wrote up the incident in careful, unembellished detail, and sent it south to the Greywall’s commander, who filed it alongside eleven similar reports collected over the preceding two years, none of which had ever received a reply from Duskhaven, because Duskhaven’s attention, that season and every season before it, was entirely consumed by a dying king and the men circling his throne.

Corbin did not sleep well that night, nor for many nights afterward, though he could never quite explain why, beyond a feeling he was ashamed to put into words: that the dead man’s folded hands had looked less like a burial and more like a message, left by something that wanted, very specifically, to be noticed.

— IV. —

Lord Halden Maddox did not spend the evening of Edran Thorne’s summons thinking about the north at all. He spent it, instead, in a windowless counting room three floors below the treasury’s public archives, meeting with a foreign banker from the free port of Cerreth named Ilio Vance, whose ships carried more discreet cargo across the Narrow Sea than any customs manifest ever recorded.

“Three hundred more men by midwinter,” Vance said, sliding a slim ledger across the table, “assuming your gold arrives on the same schedule as last quarter.”

“It will.” Maddox did not open the ledger. He had long since stopped needing to check Vance’s figures; the man’s greed was reliably, usefully predictable, which made him easier to trust than most of Maddox’s own countrymen. “Ashgrove’s granaries can hold the additional numbers through the cold months. See that they arrive in small companies, not all at once. A hunting lodge suddenly garrisoned like a fortress invites exactly the kind of questions I’d rather no one thought to ask before spring.”

“And the king?”

“Dying,” Maddox said, without particular emotion, “and slower than I’d like, which is its own kind of problem. A long decline gives too many people time to notice things they’d otherwise be too busy to examine.” He considered, briefly, the letter he had already dispatched north under the crown’s own seal, and the honest, inconvenient lord it would shortly deliver into a capital built, however invisibly,

entirely around men like Ilio Vance and the private soldiers his gold was quietly buying. “Fortunately, I believe that particular problem is about to solve itself rather more quickly than the physicians currently expect.”

He did not elaborate, and Vance, wisely, did not ask him to.



HOUSE THORNE

WE DO NOT BREAK



I.

In the three days between the raven's arrival and Edran's departure, Lyra quietly took over the daily running of Wintermoor's household accounts, a task she had technically shared with her father's steward for two years already but had never before been asked to manage entirely alone.

She found, somewhat to her own surprise, that she was good at it — better, in some ways, than the steward himself, who deferred to her judgment on a disputed grain shipment from the eastern farms with a promptness that suggested he had perhaps always suspected her sharper mind and simply lacked the occasion to test it. She balanced the autumn tithes, settled a boundary dispute between two tenant farmers that had been simmering unresolved for a month, and reviewed, with new and deliberate attention, every piece of correspondence passing in or out of Wintermoor's gates — a habit that would prove, in the difficult year ahead, considerably more valuable than anyone in that quiet autumn household yet understood.

It was in the course of that new attention that she first noticed the green-sashed tax rider who passed through Wintermoor village twice in a single week, an unusual frequency for a district that had, by long tradition, been assessed and collected only twice a year.

"He's counting something," she told her father, the night before he left. "Not coin. Men, maybe, or grain stores — he's too interested in the granary doors for a simple tax collection."

Edran considered this with the same careful attention he gave everything his daughter brought to him. "Keep a count of your own, then," he said. "How often he comes, what he asks after, who he speaks with in the village. Small things, written down and compared over months, tell a story that no single visit ever will."

It was, though neither of them could have known it that night, the beginning of exactly the kind of patient intelligence-gathering that would, within the year, prove far more useful to House Thorne's survival than any single dramatic act of defiance ever could have.

II.



They left three days later, at first light, twenty riders under the Thorne banner — a gray wolf's-head on white — cutting south along the King's Road with Edran at their head and his eldest son, Kael, riding at his shoulder.

Kael Thorne was twenty, built like his father though not yet weathered the way his father was, more comfortable with a sword in his hand than a clever phrase on his tongue, which had made him, his whole life, the steadier and less interesting of Edran's children by the estimation of everyone except Edran himself, who privately believed steadiness was the rarer and more valuable trait, whatever the songs said about cleverness.

"You're quiet," Edran said, on the second day, when the road had narrowed to a single track through pine forest and the rest of the party had fallen back out of easy earshot.

"I'm thinking about what we're riding into."

"And?"

"And I don't like that Lyra's the one who worked it out before either of us said it aloud. A dying king. A hungry treasurer. A prince who can't rule alone." Kael's jaw worked. "It sounds like the kind of story that ends with somebody's head on a spike, Father, and I don't love the odds that it isn't ours."

Edran laughed — a short, real sound, rare enough on that road that two of the outriders glanced back in surprise. "No," he agreed. "Nor do I, if I'm honest. But there's a difference between walking blind into a trap and walking into one with your eyes open, weapons loose, and every possible exit already mapped in your head. I intend to do the second."

"And if there's no exit?"

"Then I die exactly the way I've lived — telling the truth to men who'd rather I hadn't. Which is, all things considered, not the worst way a Thorne has ever gone."

They rode on, and did not speak of it again that day, though Kael found, over the following nights, that he slept with one hand near his sword hilt more often than he used to.

— III. —

On the third day the road crested a low ridge, and the Greywall came into view along the northern horizon — eight hundred feet of black, ancient stone running east to west farther than the eye could follow, unbroken except at the great gate near Wintermoor's own lands, where a garrison a tenth the size it had been in Edran's grandfather's day still kept watch over a border most of the realm had stopped believing needed watching.

Edran reined in without quite meaning to, and sat a long moment looking north, past the wall itself, toward the pale, silent country beyond — the Hollow Marches, white and flat and utterly still under a sky the color of an old bruise.

"You feel that," he said, not really a question, echoing almost exactly what he would say to Kael again in memory many months later, in circumstances neither of them could yet imagine.

“Feel what?”

“Nothing.” Edran frowned, trying to find better words for a sensation that resisted them. “That’s the trouble. There should be something to feel — wind, birds, the ordinary business of a cold country going about its cold business. Instead there’s nothing, like the land itself is holding its breath.”

Kael, who possessed his father’s instincts if not always his patience for examining them, found that he did not want to look north any longer than necessary, and was faintly, uselessly ashamed of the impulse.

They did not linger. There was a dying king waiting six hundred miles south, and neither of them yet understood that the empty, breath-held quiet of the Hollow Marches was, in its own patient way, a summons at least as urgent as the one folded in Edran’s coat.

— IV. —

Duskhaven announced itself first as a smudge of woodsmoke on the horizon, then as a smell — tar and salt and unwashed crowds — and finally, on the eighteenth day, as a city that had grown considerably more desperate than Edran remembered from his last visit a decade before.

The processional road, which he recalled lined with silk merchants and flower sellers, was now lined instead with beggars, thin-faced and silent, watching the Thorne banner pass with the particular hollow patience of people who had learned that hope cost more than it returned. Green-sashed tax collectors moved through the crowd at intervals, and Edran noted, with a soldier’s habit of counting things, that there seemed to be a great many more of them than the city’s ordinary business could explain.

“Maddox’s men,” Kael murmured.

“Maddox’s men,” Edran agreed. “Collecting a great deal more than the crown’s ordinary levies would require, unless I’ve badly misjudged the cost of a physician’s silence.”

The Iron Court itself rose above the city’s rooftops the way it always had — a fortress-palace of black stone and colder ambition, its throne room windows glowing gold in the late afternoon light — and Edran felt, crossing beneath its outer gate for the first time in ten years, the same complicated mixture he always felt entering Duskhaven: pride in the kingdom his family had helped hold together for eleven generations, and a deep, old wariness of the particular kind of rot that only grows in rooms with good lighting and better manners.

They were shown, not to the king, but to Prince Corwin, who received them in a smaller receiving hall with the Iron Court itself standing empty and unclaimed behind him, as no one but a crowned monarch could sit there while the crown’s current owner still drew breath.

Corwin Voss was slighter than Edran remembered, dressed in more gold thread than a man his age needed to prove anything, with his father’s dark hair and none, yet, of his father’s weathered certainty. But his smile, when he rose to greet them, was unguarded in a way that surprised Edran — the smile of a young man genuinely relieved to see a familiar, trustworthy face in a palace that had

apparently stopped offering him many of those.

“Lord Thorne.” He crossed the room himself rather than waiting for Edran to approach, an informality that made the Maddox-liveried guards along the walls exchange a glance Edran filed away for later. “My father speaks of no one else, these last weeks. He says you’re the only honest man left in this kingdom who still remembers how to hold both a sword and a promise.”

“Your father is generous, my prince.”

“My father,” Corwin said, and here his voice dropped, quiet enough that only Edran and Kael could hear it, his eyes flicking once, briefly, toward the nearest guard, “is very possibly the only reason I am not already dead, and I don’t say that as an exaggeration for effect. Walk with me. If such a thing as a private conversation still exists in this palace, I’d like very much to have one with you before the evening’s out.”

V.

They walked the palace’s outer gardens as the sun went down, ostensibly admiring the last of the season’s roses, and Corwin talked, quietly and quickly, like a man who had been saving up words for a listener he could finally trust.

He told Edran about the vanishing gold — modest sums at first, easily explained as wartime reserves or harvest shortfalls, but growing, over the past two years, into amounts that no honest accounting could justify. He told him about Maddox’s green-sashed collectors, whose numbers had tripled in eighteen months while the crown’s official garrison had, oddly, shrunk. He told him, in a voice gone thin with something between grief and fear, about his father’s sudden decline, which Maester Yrsa privately believed had been hastened, though she dared not say so plainly to anyone but the prince himself, by something other than natural illness.

“You think he’s being poisoned,” Edran said quietly.

“I think,” Corwin said, “that I don’t know who to trust enough to ask the question louder than a whisper in a garden at dusk. My father trusts Maddox because Maddox has been useful to him for twenty years. I don’t trust anyone, because everyone useful to my father has spent those same twenty years becoming considerably more useful to themselves.” He stopped walking, turning to face Edran directly, and for a moment looked less like a spoiled prince and more like a frightened young man asking, plainly, for help. “My father wants you to protect me when he’s gone. I want that too. But I need you to understand what you’re agreeing to before you agree to it. This isn’t a court. It’s a nest of vipers wearing a crown for a hat, and I don’t know how much longer I can keep pretending I don’t see the fangs.”

Edran considered him for a long moment — this soft, frightened, not-unintelligent young man who would, in a matter of weeks or less, be given a kingdom he had no idea how to hold — and felt something settle in his chest that was equal parts pity and grim resolve.

“I swore an oath to your father a long time before I ever met you,” he said. “I intend to keep it. Which means yes, my prince — I understand precisely what I’m agreeing to. I simply intend to be

considerably harder to remove from this palace than whoever's currently counting on my absence."

It was, he would think much later, the kind of promise that sounded like courage in a rose garden at dusk, and felt like something else entirely by the time he was kneeling on cold stone steps with a crowd of strangers watching him die for a crime he had never committed.

That night, alone in guest chambers hung with unfamiliar tapestries, Edran began a letter to Lyra warning her that the rot in Duskhaven ran deeper and more deliberately than either of them had guessed, that she should trust no raven lacking his personal seal twisted twice at the wax, and that whatever happened to him, she was to protect her younger brother and wait for word from Kael before doing anything rash.

He began a second letter as well — this one detailing his growing suspicions about Maddox's private soldiers, the vanishing treasury gold, and the strange, tripled army of tax collectors moving through a city that seemed, by every outward measure, to be growing poorer rather than richer.

He did not finish the second letter. It felt, even half-written, too dangerous a thing to commit fully to paper in a palace where he had already begun to suspect the walls themselves might be listening. He told himself he would finish it once he had gathered proof rather than suspicion.

He would never get the chance.



HOUSE MADDOX
WHAT IS OWED, IS OWED



I.

Duskhaven ran on secrets the way a body runs on blood, and within a fortnight Edran Thorne had made the fatal mistake of believing he understood its currents.

He did not know about Vessa, the young cupbearer who filled Corwin's wine each evening and reported every word spoken in the prince's chambers to Maddox's steward before the cups were even cleared. He did not know that the treasury ledgers Corwin had quietly granted him leave to examine — seeking hard proof of the vanishing gold rather than mere suspicion — had themselves been seeded, months in advance, with false entries designed to lead any careful auditor toward a very particular, very wrong, and very fatal conclusion. He did not know that Lord Halden Maddox had decided, the very morning the king's raven flew north, that a man with Edran Thorne's reputation for stubborn honesty was not an ally to be managed, but a threat to be removed — cleanly, thoroughly, and blamed upon someone else entirely.

Edran spent his days in the treasury archives, a windowless room of towering shelves and older, mustier ledgers than the ones in current use, working with a young clerk named Tobin who had been assigned to assist him and who was, though Edran did not yet suspect it, entirely loyal to Maddox and reporting every discovery in real time.

"Here," Edran said, on the ninth day, tapping a column of figures that did not balance against the corresponding harvest reports from three southern provinces. "This is the third instance I've found. Grain taxes recorded as collected, but the corresponding silver never reaching the crown's central accounts. Where does it go instead?"

"I couldn't say, my lord," Tobin said, with the practiced blankness of a man who could say a great deal more than he was willing to. "Perhaps a clerical error. The old system was replaced two years back — much was lost in the transition."

"Two years," Edran repeated slowly. "That's precisely when the shortfalls begin."

He did not say aloud what he was already beginning to suspect: that the "clerical error"



explanation was itself the trap, designed to lead him toward Maddox's genuine crime — the systematic diversion of crown taxes — while simultaneously burying, beneath the same false entries, evidence of an entirely different and far more damning scheme that Edran would not uncover until it was already too late to use.

II.

Six hundred miles north, in Wintermoor's own village, Lyra Thorne had begun an education of a very different kind.

Sable, the seventeen-year-old daughter of the village's grain merchant, had a gift her father found more troublesome than useful: a near-total memory for anything she overheard, coupled with an insatiable curiosity about exactly the sort of conversations well-mannered girls were meant to pretend not to notice. She had been Lyra's friend since childhood, the two of them united originally by a shared contempt for needlework and a shared love of the old border histories, and it was Sable who came to Wintermoor's kitchen door on a bitter afternoon with a folded paper she had, by her own cheerful admission, stolen from a Maddox courier's saddlebag while he drank himself stupid at her father's inn.

"He's been through twice this month," Sable said, spreading the paper across the kitchen table while the cook pretended not to listen. "Same route each time — south toward the old Ashgrove hunting lodge, never toward Duskhaven directly. I got curious."

Lyra scanned the paper — a payment ledger, dense with names and figures, written in a shorthand she recognized after a moment as the same coded notation her father used for sensitive correspondence, though this hand was not his.

"These are wages," she said slowly. "Soldiers' wages. Nearly three hundred names." She ran a finger down the column, doing rough sums in her head. "Paid in gold, not crown coin — someone's private purse, not the treasury. And Ashgrove's not a crown garrison. It's a private hunting lodge that's belonged to the Maddox family for two generations."

"An army," Sable said, "that doesn't officially exist."

"An army for what, though." Lyra sat back, feeling something cold settle beneath her ribs that had nothing to do with the drafty kitchen. "Maddox already holds half the realm's debts. He doesn't need soldiers to collect what men already owe him willingly, out of fear of their ledgers."

"Maybe he's not planning to collect debts."

Lyra looked up at her friend, and for a moment neither of them said the word that had occurred to both — *coup* — because saying it aloud in a Wintermoor kitchen felt like inviting it to become real a moment sooner than it needed to.

"I have to write to my father," Lyra said instead. "Tonight."

She did — a careful letter, twisting her personal seal twice at the wax exactly as her father had taught her, describing the payment ledger, the hidden garrison, the pattern of the courier's route —

and sent it south by her fastest raven before the hour was out.

It would take the bird four days to reach Duskhaven under good conditions. It would take considerably longer than that, in the end, because the raven — like so much else moving toward Edran Thorne that season — never actually arrived.

Sable came back twice more that autumn, each time with some new fragment gleaned from a drunk courier or a careless guardsman passing through her father's inn: the name of the foreign banker whose ships kept Ashgrove's granaries stocked; a rumor, unconfirmed, that the lodge's soldiers drilled at night rather than by day, to avoid being counted by curious travelers; a passing mention, overheard and only half understood, of a "cupbearer's girl" in the capital whose nerves, according to the courier repeating the gossip, had gone to pieces since some unspecified trouble at court.

"None of it proves anything," Sable admitted, the third time, spreading her latest scraps of overheard conversation across the same kitchen table. "It's just noise. Fragments."

"Fragments add up," Lyra said, writing each one down in the same careful, coded hand she used for her father's letters, filed now in a growing collection she kept locked in her mother's old jewelry chest rather than trusted to any single letter that might go astray. "One day soon, they'll add up to something we can actually use. I intend to still be listening when they do."

III.

Vessa was nineteen years old, the daughter of a Duskhaven dockworker who had drowned in the harbor when she was eleven, and she had come to the palace at fourteen through the kind of arrangement that polite society preferred not to examine too closely: a debt her mother owed, quietly transferred to House Maddox, quietly repaid instead through years of small, deniable services rendered by a girl too young and too poor to refuse.

She did not think of herself as a spy, when she thought about it at all, which she tried not to do more than necessary. She thought of herself as someone doing what was required to keep her mother's remaining debts from being called in all at once, in a lump sum that would have put both of them on the street, or worse. She filled cups. She emptied chamber pots. She listened, because listening was easy and cost her nothing extra, and she reported what she heard to Maddox's steward, a soft-spoken man named Aldous who always thanked her politely and always paid exactly on time, which was more consideration than most of the nobles she served ever bothered to show her.

She liked Lord Thorne, in the small, uncomplicated way one might like any employer who spoke to servants as though they were people rather than furniture. He had thanked her, twice, for refilling his cup — an unremarkable courtesy that had nonetheless struck her as unusual enough to remember — and he had never once looked at her the way some of the younger lords did, as though calculating what else she might be persuaded to provide beyond wine.

When Aldous came to her three days before the king's fatal fever, with a small vial and instructions to see it emptied into a particular silver cup and that cup left, afterward, somewhere it would be found in Lord Thorne's chambers rather than the king's, she did not ask what the vial contained. She told

herself, in the days that followed, that she genuinely hadn't known — that "something to help him sleep more soundly" was a plausible enough lie for her to have believed it, if she'd wanted to.

She had wanted to. That was the part she would carry, afterward, longer and heavier than almost anything else in that terrible year: not that she'd been deceived, but that she'd chosen, in the moment it mattered, not to ask the one question that might have spared an honest man's life, because asking it might have cost her the only stability she and her mother had left.

She did not sleep well the week of Edran Thorne's execution. She told herself, watching from the edge of the crowd with her hood drawn up against recognition, that this was simply grief for a stranger who had once been kind to her. It would be some months yet before she let herself understand it, more honestly, as the first small crack in a loyalty she had never actually chosen for herself in the first place — a crack that would, much later, in circumstances she could not yet imagine, open just wide enough to matter.

— IV. —

The king took his fatal turn on the nineteenth night of Edran's stay.

It began, according to the physicians summoned in a panic near midnight, as a sudden and violent fever entirely unlike the slow, grinding decline that had marked the previous months — a fever that left Aldric Voss thrashing and incoherent within the hour, his skin gone hot enough to blister at the touch, while Maester Yrsa and two junior physicians worked over him with poultices and desperate, half-remembered remedies that did nothing at all to slow whatever had taken hold.

Edran had been with the king for nearly an hour that evening, at Aldric's own quiet request, the two of them talking — as much as the king's failing strength allowed — of old campaigns, dead friends, and the particular loneliness of ruling a kingdom that had stopped being grateful for its own survival. It was, in retrospect, one of the last genuinely peaceful conversations either man would have, though neither recognized it as such at the time.

Edran had touched nothing in that chamber but the king's hand, and the arm of his own chair, and, briefly, a cup of watered wine offered to him by a serving girl he did not recognize and would, in the frantic hours that followed, be entirely unable to describe with any useful specificity to the guards who came asking.

By dawn, the whole palace knew the king had taken a violent and unexplained turn. By midmorning, word had spread — carried, with suspicious efficiency, by servants whose loyalties Edran would later understand ran directly to Maddox's household — that the last man to sit alone with the king before the fever struck had been the newly arrived Lord Thorne of Wintermoor.

By midday, Maddox's own guard captain, a grim, competent man named Ser Renner Voss — no relation to the royal family beyond a common ancestor eight generations back, though he traded on the confusion when it suited him — arrived at Edran's guest chambers with four armed men and a single, quiet accusation.

"A cup was found in your chambers this morning, my lord," Renner said, not unkindly, holding up a

silver goblet Edran had never seen before in his life. “Tested by the royal physician not an hour ago. Oleander, my lord. Enough to kill a strong man twice over, let alone one already weakened by illness.”

“I’ve never seen that cup,” Edran said, with the particular flat calm of a man who understood, in the space of a single sentence, precisely how thoroughly and how patiently he had been outmaneuvered. “I drink from my own vessels, brought from Wintermoor. Search them if you doubt me.”

“We have, my lord. They’re clean.” Renner’s expression did not change, though something in his eyes suggested he, too, found the tidiness of the evidence faintly distasteful. “Which is, if I may say so, rather the trouble. An innocent man’s chambers are usually a mess of contradictions. Yours are suspiciously, perfectly clean of everything except the one cup that damns you.”

He was given, at least, the small mercy of a council hearing before sentence — a formality Maddox permitted, Edran suspected even as it was happening, only because a hearing with a foregone conclusion looked considerably better in the retelling than no hearing at all.

The small council chamber was crowded that afternoon with lords who had, weeks earlier, greeted Edran’s arrival with cautious respect, and now regarded him with the particular, careful blankness of men calculating how much distance they needed to put between themselves and a falling house before the fall was complete.

“You were alone with the king for the better part of an hour,” Maddox said, pacing before the assembled council with the unhurried confidence of a man who had already won and was simply enjoying the formality of proving it. “You touched his hand. You accepted wine from a cup that has never, in the whole of its existence, sat in your own chambers before that night — and yet somehow it was found there afterward, bearing traces of a poison rare enough that perhaps three merchants in this entire city could supply it.”

“Then find the merchant,” Edran said. “Ask him who purchased it. I’ve never in my life handled oleander, nor had cause to.”

“We have asked,” Maddox said, and something in the smoothness of the answer told Edran, with sick certainty, exactly how thoroughly that particular avenue had already been closed to him. “The merchant in question died of a fever himself, three days past. Tragic timing. The city’s been unwell this season.”

A murmur moved through the gathered lords — not disbelief, exactly, but the beginning of it, a seed Edran could see taking root in at least two or three faces even as Maddox continued speaking, smooth and reasonable and utterly, deliberately unassailable.

“I did not poison my king,” Edran said, addressing the council directly now rather than Maddox, because he understood, watching their faces, that this was the only genuine chance remaining to him. “I have served this crown honestly for twenty years, and I would ask any man in this chamber who has known me that whole time to say, plainly, whether dishonesty is a trait he has ever once observed in me.”

The silence that followed was not agreement. It was something worse — the silence of men who believed him, individually, and had already calculated, collectively, that believing him aloud would cost more than staying quiet ever could.

“Then someone placed it there.”

“Perhaps.” Renner’s men were already moving to flank him. “That’s a question for the council, my lord, not for me. I’m sorry. I liked you, from the little I knew of you. That won’t save either of us from what happens next.”



HOUSE THORNE

WE DO NOT BREAK



I.

They did not execute him quietly, and Edran understood, the moment he learned the sentence would be carried out on the steps of the Iron Court at midday rather than in some discreet interior yard, exactly why Maddox had insisted on it.

A private killing invites doubt. A public one, however monstrous, invites only fear — and fear, unlike doubt, does not ask inconvenient questions.

He spent his last night in a cell beneath the palace's western tower, cold and undecorated, and used the hours not in prayer or despair but in the same clear, methodical thinking that had made him, for eleven generations running the northern marches, a Thorne worth trusting. He wrote, by the light of a single guttering candle a sympathetic guard had smuggled him, a final letter to Lyra — not the unfinished one about Maddox's private army, which he had left behind in his guest chambers and which he suspected, correctly, had already been quietly destroyed, but a shorter, more urgent one, containing only what mattered most: *Trust no one wearing green. Protect your brother. Watch the north — I fear now there was always a second war beneath this one, and I never had time to understand it before this one swallowed me.*

He gave the letter to the same guard, along with the single ring he still wore — his father's, and his father's father's before that — and asked, simply, that both reach Wintermoor by whatever means the man could manage. Whether the guard succeeded, or whether he too answered to Maddox in the end, Edran would never learn.

II.

King Aldric Voss died an hour before dawn without ever waking from his fever, which meant that by the time Edran Thorne was led out onto the black steps of the Iron Court at midday, the man standing at the top of those steps to pronounce sentence was no longer a prince acting on a council's advice, but a king acting — or being made to appear to act — entirely on his own new authority.

Corwin looked, Edran thought, watching him from below with hands bound and guards at each



shoulder, like a man being slowly hollowed out from the inside while his face remained perfectly, terribly composed.

“You tried to object,” Edran called up to him — the only words he spoke aloud that whole final morning, quiet enough that only those nearest the steps could hear them clearly, but loud enough that Corwin certainly did. “I know you did. I can see it on you even now. Don’t let them make a habit of that hollowness, my king. It’s the only warning I have left to give you.”

Corwin’s composure did not break, though something behind his eyes clearly did. Beside him, Maddox stood close enough to rest one steady hand on the young king’s shoulder, and Edran, watching, understood with perfect clarity that the hand was not comfort. It was a leash, disguised as one.

The crowd that had gathered — nobles and commoners both, drawn by rumor and dread in equal measure — fell silent as the herald read the charges: regicide, by poison, against the crown’s own dying sovereign. Somewhere in that crowd, unnoticed by anyone who mattered, Kael Thorne stood with his hand locked white-knuckled around his sword hilt, held back from the steps themselves by four of Maddox’s guardsmen who had, with quiet efficiency, surrounded him the moment the sentence was announced, precisely to prevent exactly what he was contemplating.

He broke free anyway, in the final moment, drawing steel and cutting down two guardsmen before the other four brought him to the ground, wounded across the ribs and the left arm but, by some grim mercy of circumstance rather than intention, not killed outright — a fact Maddox would later regret, quietly, as the single loose thread in an otherwise flawless plan.

Edran, kneeling now at the executioner’s block with the whole width of Duskhaven watching, did not plead and did not curse Maddox’s name, because he understood, in the clear, cold way that came to him only in moments of genuine extremity, that neither would save his life, and both would only hand the watching crowd a more satisfying story than the truth deserved. Instead, he searched the crowd until he found his son’s eyes, held there across all that terrible distance, and did not look away until the executioner’s blade ended the search for him.

— III. —

King Aldric Voss’s funeral and Lord Edran Thorne’s execution occupied the same week of the capital’s calendar, an overlap the smallfolk of Duskhaven would speak of for years afterward in hushed, superstitious tones, as though the timing itself had been some deliberate cruelty of the gods rather than the far more mundane cruelty of men.

Kael, his wounds bound but his fever high, was smuggled out of the capital within two days by a handful of loyal Thorne bannermen who had accompanied the original party south — not out of any mercy on Maddox’s part, but because Maddox had calculated, correctly, that a grieving, wounded, discredited young lord posed considerably less threat wandering the countryside than he would as a martyr executed alongside his father in the same terrible week.

In Wintermoor, three days after the execution, a raven arrived bearing House Maddox’s crown seal

rather than a Thorne family letter, and Lyra Thorne broke the wax with hands that had already gone cold with a foreboding she could not yet name.

By order of the crown, Lord Edran Thorne of Wintermoor has been found guilty of the poisoning and murder of His Grace King Aldric Voss, and has been justly executed on the steps of the Iron Court. House Thorne's lands and titles are, for the present, left undisturbed in recognition of the family's long and previously honorable service, pending further review by the crown's council.

She read it twice, then a third time, as though rereading it enough times might eventually reveal it to be some cruel misunderstanding rather than a plain, deliberate lie dressed in official language.

She did not cry. Not then, and not in front of the household, because she understood — with a clarity that frightened her, arriving as it did alongside grief rather than instead of it — that whatever came next would require every ounce of composure she could hold onto, and that there would be time later, alone, behind a locked door, to fall apart properly where no enemy could see it and mistake it for weakness.

What she felt instead, standing in her father's empty study with his half-burned, unfinished letter still sitting cold in the hearth where he'd left it weeks before, was something quieter and considerably more dangerous than grief.

It was the very beginning of a plan.

— IV. —

Word of Edran Thorne's execution reached Duskhaven's smallfolk considerably faster and considerably more honestly than House Maddox would have preferred.

The official account — regicide, proven, justly punished — circulated through the noble quarters within the day, dutifully repeated by every lord and lady with sense enough to be seen agreeing with the crown's version of events. But the docks and the tanneries and the crowded, unglamorous streets where Duskhaven's actual population lived and worked told a different story by nightfall, one that owed nothing to official proclamation and everything to a hundred small, unremarkable witnesses: the serving girl who'd seen Lord Thorne thank a cupbearer by name; the palace groundskeeper who'd overheard two Maddox guardsmen laughing, three days before the execution, about a "tidy little arrangement" they'd been paid handsomely to forget; the washerwoman whose cousin worked the treasury archives and swore, quietly and only to family, that the ledgers Lord Thorne had been examining showed a pattern of theft that pointed nowhere near Wintermoor.

None of it was proof. All of it, together, was something nearly as dangerous to Maddox as proof would have been: doubt, spreading slowly and unstoppably through a population that had already learned, across two years of tripled taxes and a vanishing treasury, to trust its own eyes over its rulers' proclamations.

Kael Thorne, recovering under a false name in a fisherman's cottage two days' ride from the capital, heard a version of this same rumor from the very bannermen who'd smuggled him out — men who had, in turn, heard it from a Duskhaven contact loyal enough to House Thorne to risk passing

word north despite the danger.

“They don’t believe it,” said Aldwin, the eldest of the loyal bannermen, keeping his voice low though there was no one else in the cottage to overhear. “Not all of them. Not even most of them, from what I hear. It’s not enough to save your father, my lord. But it’s something.”

Kael, still fevered, still grieving in the raw, unprocessed way of a man who had watched his father die and had not yet had the stillness required to properly feel it, found the news landed strangely — not as comfort, exactly, but as the first small foothold of something he would need in the difficult months ahead, though he could not yet have named what that something was.

“Doubt isn’t justice,” he said.

“No, my lord.” Aldwin’s weathered face was unreadable in the cottage’s dim firelight. “But justice generally needs somewhere to stand before it can start walking. Doubt’s as good a place as any I’ve seen offered.”



HOUSE THORNE

WE DO NOT BREAK



I.

The realm did not pause to mourn Edran Thorne. It could not afford to, and Lord Halden Maddox made certain of it.

King Aldric Voss's official funeral rites lasted the traditional nine days, during which the whole of the capital dressed in gray and the temple bells tolled every hour from dawn to dusk, and by the time the ninth day ended, Corwin Voss had been crowned King Corwin the First in a ceremony attended by every noble house with sense enough to want to be seen attending it.

He was eighteen in spirit, whatever his actual years, and everyone in that throne room understood it, none more clearly than Maddox, who stood at the new king's right hand throughout the coronation with the serene expression of a man who has just watched a very long investment finally mature.

House Thorne did not wait in Wintermoor to see what came next, because Lyra Thorne had already decided, in the cold days following her father's death, that waiting was a luxury her family could no longer afford.

Kael arrived home twelve days after fleeing the capital, fever-thin and slow from his wounds, his sword arm healing but his faith in courts and kings broken in a way that would never entirely mend. He found Wintermoor's great hall changed — not physically, but in some harder-to-name way, as though the whole keep had drawn a breath and was holding it, waiting to see what its new mistress would decide.

Because that, Kael understood within a day of his return, was precisely what Lyra had quietly become: not lady of the house in name — that title, and the burden beneath it, would eventually fall to him as eldest surviving son — but its actual mind, its actual will, in every way that mattered while grief and fever kept him too weak to claim the role himself.

"You've already decided something," he said, watching her spread maps across their father's old worktable with the same brisk economy of motion Edran himself used to employ.

"I've decided several somethings." She did not look up. "The first is that we cannot fight Maddox



from Wintermoor with three hundred spears against whatever private army he's built at Ashgrove. He'd crush us before the first snow and call it justice for our father's crimes."

"Then what?"

"Then we don't fight him yet. We survive him, and we watch, and we wait for him to make the kind of mistake that men who believe they've already won always eventually make." She finally looked up, and Kael saw in her face an exhaustion far older than her sixteen years, sitting alongside something colder and more resolute beneath it. "And in the meantime, we make sure there isn't a single remaining Thorne left in one place for him to finish what he started."

II.

Wren Thorne was twelve years old, quiet and watchful in the particular way of youngest children who have spent their whole lives listening to older, louder siblings decide things on their behalf, and he did not want to leave Wintermoor at all.

"I can fight," he told Lyra, with the fierce, brittle dignity of a boy trying very hard not to cry in front of his sister. "Kael's teaching me the sword. I could stay and help."

"You could," Lyra agreed, crouching to meet his eyes properly, because she understood — better than Kael did, better perhaps than their father ever had — that Wren needed to be reasoned with as a person rather than commanded as a child. "And if Maddox never thinks to look for a third Thorne child, that would be a fine plan. But he will think of it, Wren, the moment it's useful to him, and I would rather you were three hundred miles away learning a false name than here, learning to hold a sword against soldiers who'd cut you down before you got the chance to use it."

He was smuggled east within the week, across the narrow strait to a household of distant Thorne cousins who had married into minor eastern nobility two generations back and owed the family enough old loyalty to take in a frightened boy under a name that was not his own and ask no questions loud enough for anyone else to hear the answers.

Lyra herself made, in some ways, the hardest choice of the three. She did not ride south seeking vengeance, as half of Wintermoor's remaining bannermen quietly expected her to, and she did not remain at Wintermoor to manage the household in her brother's stead, as tradition would have suggested was her proper place.

Instead, she rode north, to the Greywall itself, carrying with her three wagons of Wintermoor grain, a letter of introduction bearing her father's old seal, and eleven of the ancient border histories she had already read twice as a girl and now intended to read a third time with rather more urgent purpose.

III.

Ser Osric Farrow, commander of the Greywall's dwindling garrison, was sixty years old, half-blind in one eye from an old border skirmish, and had spent the last decade watching his once-proud order shrink under a court that no longer believed the wall's ancient purpose mattered.

He received Lyra Thorne in his spare, cold quarters with the wary courtesy of a man unaccustomed to noble visitors, particularly ones young enough to be his granddaughter and grieving enough to have every reasonable excuse for staying home instead.

"You could rally your father's bannermen, my lady," he told her, once she'd explained, plainly and without embellishment, both her family's ruin and her reasons for coming north instead of south. "Fight for justice. Half of Wintermoor would follow a Thorne banner into that fight gladly, whatever the odds."

"Half of Wintermoor would die for a war I don't believe we can win," Lyra said, "against a man who already controls the treasury, the young king's ear, and — as far as I can tell — a private army nobody in the capital has officially acknowledged exists. Revenge is a war Maddox already knows exactly how to fight and win. I'd rather fight the one he hasn't noticed is happening at all."

"And which war is that?"

She set the border histories on his table, opened to a page she had marked with a strip of gray cloth. "The reports you've been sending south for two years. The dead men found unmarked in the snow. The ones who don't stay dead." She met his single working eye steadily. "I don't think anyone in Duskhaven has read a single one of them properly. I'd like to help you understand what's actually happening out there before it stops being the north's private problem."

Osric studied her for a long moment — long enough that she began to wonder if she'd misjudged him entirely, if he too would dismiss her as a grieving girl chasing ghosts to avoid grieving properly — and then, slowly, he nodded.

"My old master-at-arms used to say the same thing, thirty years back, before the court stopped listening to him too," he said. "Welcome to the Greywall, Lady Thorne. I hope to every god still watching that you're wrong about what's coming. I've a bad feeling you're not."

— IV. —

Wren Thorne became, within a month of crossing the Narrow Sea, a boy named Wren Ashby, nephew to a minor eastern house called Ashby that owed the Thornes an old debt of loyalty dating back three generations to a border dispute Wren's own grandfather had settled in the Ashbys' favor at some personal cost.

He was not unhappy, exactly, in his new life — the Ashby household was kind enough, in its distracted way, and the eastern coast where they kept their modest seat was warmer than Wintermoor had ever been, with a gentler sea and gulls instead of the sharp-toothed winter wind he'd grown up under — but he was lonely in a manner he did not have the vocabulary yet to properly name, surrounded by cousins who were not really his cousins, sleeping in a room that was not really his room, answering, with increasing but still imperfect ease, to a name that was not really his name.

He kept, hidden beneath a loose floorboard beneath his borrowed bed, the one object he'd been allowed to bring that still bore any trace of who he actually was: a small carved wolf, Wintermoor's sigil, whittled for him two winters back by Kael during a long, snowbound month when there had been

little else for either of them to do. He took it out most nights, after the household had gone quiet, and held it until his hands warmed it through, and thought about his father's steady voice and his sister's sharp, protective eyes and his brother's patient hands guiding his grip on a practice sword, and told himself, each night with slightly more conviction than the last, that this was temporary, that Lyra would send for him the moment it was safe, that being Wren Ashby was simply a coat he was wearing rather than a skin he was growing into.

He did not yet know how long, in the end, he would have to wear it.

V.

Far across the Narrow Sea, in the sun-bleached harbor city of Tessara, a young woman named Cassia Vale received news of the chaos unfolding in Duskhaven with an interest that was neither grief nor satisfaction, but something closer to long-awaited recognition.

House Vale had once been known by an older, grander name — Rhoswyn, the ancient dynasty that had ruled Maren for three centuries before the Voss family's grandfather led the rebellion that ended it, three generations and one bloody civil war ago. Cassia had been raised in exile on the stories of that fallen dynasty, told to her by advisors who had themselves been children the last time a Rhoswyn sat the Iron Throne, and she had promised herself, since she was old enough to understand what exile actually meant, that when she returned to Maren it would not be as a supplicant begging scraps of a stolen inheritance, but as a queen reclaiming what was hers by both blood and fire.

She was twenty-four now, and she had spent six years of careful, patient work earning the loyalty of exiled soldiers, foreign gold, and — more valuable than either — three emberhawks, hatched from ancient eggs no one else in Tessara had dared even attempt to incubate, now grown to the size of warhorses and bonded to her alone through a process so old and so nearly forgotten that even Cassia herself only half understood how she had managed it.

"The boy-king isn't yet crowned a week," her chief advisor, a grizzled old exile-soldier named Doran, told her as news of Corwin's coronation and Edran Thorne's execution reached them together in the same week's correspondence. "His treasurer just executed the one lord in the realm with a spotless reputation for honesty, on evidence half the smallfolk already whisper was invented. The realm's never been riper for the taking."

"Then perhaps," Cassia said, watching her largest emberhawk — a vast creature of black feather and banked ember-orange down its throat and wingtips, named Ashwing by the handlers who'd raised her from the egg — circle lazily against Tessara's harbor sky, "we shouldn't simply take it."

Doran raised an eyebrow. "My queen?"

"The stories I grew up on paint House Voss as monsters who stole a throne in blood," Cassia said slowly, working the thought out even as she spoke it aloud for the first time. "But the reports reaching us now describe a frightened eighteen-year-old controlled by his own treasurer, which is a considerably messier truth than the clean villain I was promised as a child. If I land with fire and demand his surrender, I become exactly the conqueror the old stories warned my family's enemies I

would be. But if the true villain in this story is Maddox, and not the boy wearing his crown—”

“Then perhaps the boy isn’t your enemy at all,” Doran finished. “Perhaps he’s your first ally in Maren, whether he knows it yet or not.”

“Prepare the ships,” Cassia said. “All of them. It’s time we went home — but I intend to arrive as something more useful than simply another fire descending on a burning house.”

It was, Doran thought privately, watching her walk back toward the harbor with her black hair loose in the sea wind and her emberhawk wheeling protectively overhead, either the wisest instinct he’d ever seen in her, or the most dangerous mercy a woman in her position could afford to entertain. He suspected, uneasily, that the realm they were sailing toward would decide which it was long before Cassia herself got the chance to choose.



HOUSE VALE

FIRE REMEMBERS



I.

The emberhawks came first.

Three burning silhouettes crossed the Narrow Sea a full two days ahead of Cassia's fleet, visible from Maren's southern coastal watchtowers before her ships ever broke the horizon, and by the time her flagship finally made landfall at the head of six thousand hired swords, half the southern lords along that coast had already sent quiet letters north pledging their loyalty to whichever side of the coming conflict seemed likeliest to let them keep their heads, and the other half had begun discreetly moving their gold somewhere Maddox's tax collectors couldn't reach it.

Cassia stepped onto Maren's shore for the first time in her life — she had been an infant when her family fled it, and remembered nothing of it firsthand beyond the stories — and found herself, to her own quiet surprise, unexpectedly moved by the simple, unremarkable fact of standing on soil her family had bled for across three generations of exile.

"It doesn't look like the stories," she admitted to Doran, watching gulls wheel over gray autumn cliffs that bore no resemblance to the golden, sun-drenched homeland of her childhood imagination.

"Homes rarely do, once you actually reach them," Doran said. "That's not a flaw in the homecoming, my queen. That's simply what it means to trade a story for a fact."

They made camp on the southern coast rather than marching immediately on Duskhaven, and it was there, on their third night ashore, that Cassia received the first piece of information that would shape everything that followed: a captured Maddox courier, taken quietly by her outriders while attempting to carry word of her landing north, who — under considerably less duress than he clearly expected — confirmed what Doran's spies had already begun to suspect. That King Corwin had, in the days since his coronation, grown visibly withdrawn from Maddox's council sessions. That he had been overheard, twice, questioning the treasurer's authority in front of witnesses. That there were whispers, still faint but spreading, that the young king had begun his own quiet inquiry into his father's death.



“He suspects Maddox,” Cassia said slowly, turning the courier’s testimony over along with her own earlier instinct. “He’s trapped inside his own palace with the man who likely killed his father, and he doesn’t yet have the strength or the allies to do anything about it.”

“Or,” Doran said carefully, “he’s playing a longer game than either of us gives him credit for, and this is exactly the story he wants a foreign queen’s spies to overhear.”

“Perhaps.” Cassia considered this for a long moment, turning a single loose feather from Ashwing’s molt between her fingers — a habit she’d had since childhood, when thinking hard about something that mattered. “Either way, I think it’s time we found out which, directly, rather than guessing from a captured courier’s frightened testimony. Send word to the palace. Under a flag of parley. I want to speak with the boy-king myself, before either of us commits to burning anything down.”

II.

The year between Corwin’s coronation and Cassia’s landing was, for the young king, the loneliest of his life, though he would not have described it in such simple terms at the time, being too occupied surviving it to properly name what it was costing him.

He learned, in that year, to smile through council sessions where every meaningful decision had already been made before he entered the room. He learned to drink less than he was expected to, so that his mind stayed clear enough to notice the small, accumulating signs of a kingdom being quietly hollowed out around him — new green-sashed collectors in provinces that had never needed them before, garrison postings shuffled in patterns that made sense only if one assumed the shuffling was designed to move Maddox loyalists into positions of consequence, one unremarkable transfer at a time. He learned, above all, to wait, because waiting, however bitter, was the only strategy available to a young man who understood, with growing and humiliating clarity, that he did not yet possess the strength to do anything else.

He kept, in a locked drawer in his private study, a single object that Maddox did not know existed: a folded scrap of parchment, recovered quietly by a sympathetic guard from Edran Thorne’s abandoned guest chambers before Maddox’s men had thought to search them properly, containing the beginning of an unfinished letter about vanishing treasury gold and a private army no one in the official records acknowledged. Corwin could not read enough of the damaged, half-burned page to reconstruct its full argument, but he read what remained often enough, in the quiet hours after his household had gone to sleep, that he had long since memorized every surviving word — a habit that felt, to him, like the closest thing to keeping a promise he had left available: to remember, even when he could do nothing yet to act on the memory, that an honest man had died trying to warn him, and that the debt of that death was his to eventually repay.

It was this same locked drawer, and the stubborn, quiet resolve it represented, that made him receptive — when Cassia Vale’s letter finally reached him, unburned, by a guard’s loyal hand rather than a raven Maddox could intercept — to an alliance that a more comfortable, less patient young man might have dismissed outright as an invading queen’s opening gambit rather than what it actually was: the first real opportunity, in a year of careful waiting, to finally do something about the debt he

had been carrying in silence.

III.

The letter reached Duskhaven six days later, and Maddox, predictably, intercepted it first.

He read it twice in the privacy of his own chambers — a request, polite and carefully worded, for a private audience between Queen Cassia Vale and King Corwin Voss, to discuss, in her words, “matters concerning the health and future governance of the realm we both, in our different ways, have cause to care for” — and felt, for the first time since Edran Thorne’s execution, a genuine flicker of unease.

An exiled queen with a foreign army and living emberhawks was a threat he had planned for months in advance, ever since the first reports of her fleet’s preparation reached him from paid informants in Tessara. He had contingencies. He had, quietly, already begun negotiating through intermediaries to ensure that whichever side ultimately won the coming conflict, House Maddox’s fortune — and Maddox’s own neck — would still be standing at the end of it.

What he had not planned for was the possibility that Cassia Vale might simply ask to talk.

He burned the letter, and told King Corwin nothing about it, and told himself this was simply prudent caution rather than the first small crack in a control he had, until that week, believed absolute.

But letters, he would learn within the fortnight, were not the only means by which an exiled queen and a cornered young king could find their way to each other — and the second attempt, carried not by raven but by one of Corwin’s own household guards, a man whose loyalty ran to the crown rather than to the treasury that paid his coin, reached the king’s hand directly, unread by anyone else, three days after the first letter had already turned to ash in Maddox’s private hearth.

IV.

Corwin Voss read the queen’s letter alone in his chambers at midnight, by a single candle, with the door barred against a household he had stopped fully trusting weeks before he’d even been able to name why.

He thought of Edran Thorne, kneeling on the black steps and calling up to him not a curse but a warning — *don’t let them make a habit of that hollowness* — and he thought of his father, dead of a fever that Maester Yrsa still would not discuss above a whisper, and he thought, with a clarity that frightened him more than anything else had in the whole terrible year, that he had perhaps three choices left available to him: remain Maddox’s puppet for however many years the man found him useful; attempt, alone and unprepared, to move against a treasurer who controlled his own household guard more thoroughly than the crown itself did; or reach, quietly and at enormous personal risk, toward the one force in the realm that might actually be strong enough to help him do the second thing without simply dying in the attempt.

He wrote his reply that same night, in his own hand, trusting no scribe: *I would welcome such a conversation, Your Grace, though I must ask you to understand the difficulty of my present position with more precision than a letter safely allows. I am not free to speak as plainly as I would wish,*

within these walls. If there is a way to meet where neither of us is overheard by ears that answer to interests other than our own, I would count it among the few genuinely useful things to happen to me since I took this crown.

He sealed it with his own personal signet, rather than the crown's official seal, and gave it to the same household guard, and spent the following three weeks in a state of quiet, controlled dread, uncertain whether he had just taken the first real step toward saving his kingdom, or handed Maddox the final piece of evidence needed to remove him entirely.

V.

Doran had entered Duskhaven eleven days before Cassia's letter ever reached Maddox's hands, traveling alone and unremarked as a horse trader from the eastern provinces, a disguise he had worn so many times over the preceding six years of preparation that it had begun to feel, uncomfortably, almost as natural as his own skin.

He spent those eleven days doing what he did best: listening in taverns, buying rounds for indiscreet guardsmen, and cross-referencing every rumor against the hard, dull economics of grain prices and garrison wages that so rarely lied even when the people repeating them did. By the fifth day he had confirmed the private army at Ashgrove, its approximate size, and the foreign banker's ships that supplied its gold. By the eighth, he had identified, through a chain of increasingly nervous informants, the treasury clerk named Tobin who had reported Edran Thorne's every discovery directly to Maddox's steward. By the eleventh, sitting in a dockside tavern with a cup of watered wine he had no intention of finishing, he overheard two off-duty palace servants discussing, in low, uneasy voices, a young cupbearer named Vessa who had not been seen smiling since the execution, and had lately taken to walking the palace corridors, they said, like a woman carrying something too heavy to set down.

He reported all of it back to Cassia by coded letter before her own message to the king had even been drafted, and it was Doran's patient, unglamorous groundwork — rather than any single dramatic revelation — that let Cassia approach Corwin already knowing, with tolerable confidence, that the frightened young king's account of his own captivity was almost certainly true rather than a trap laid to draw her forces into a slaughter.

"You didn't tell me about the cupbearer," Cassia said, once his full report had reached her.

"I didn't know what to make of her yet," Doran admitted. "A guilty conscience walking those halls could be an asset, in time, or it could simply get a frightened girl killed before she's useful to anyone. I thought it wiser to watch a little longer before deciding which."

He would be proven right, in the end, though neither of them yet knew it: that same guilty conscience, walking those same corridors a few weeks further on, would prove the single thread that finally unraveled Maddox's entire careful scheme.

VI.

They met, in the end, in the least likely place either of them could have proposed: the ruined river

chapel a half-day's ride outside Duskhaven, abandoned since a flood two decades back had shifted the river's course and left the old stone building stranded on ground too waterlogged for the temple to bother rebuilding. Corwin knew it because he had gone there as a boy, sneaking away from his tutors; Cassia's advisors chose it because it lay far enough from both the city and her own camp that neither side's watchers were likely to think of it first.

Corwin came with two guards he trusted absolutely — a smaller number than any of his advisors would have permitted, had any of his advisors known he was going at all — and Cassia came with none, dismounting from Ashwing herself in the chapel's overgrown yard in a manner calculated, Corwin understood immediately, to demonstrate exactly how little she feared whatever trap he might have set for her.

"You came without your treasurer," she said, by way of greeting, studying him with open, unhurried curiosity. "That either means you trust me more than I expected, or you're considerably braver than the reports suggested."

"Neither, Your Grace." Corwin's voice was steadier than he felt. "It means I no longer know which of my own guards report to Maddox rather than to me, and I decided the fewer people who knew about this meeting, the better my odds of surviving to have it."

Something in his blunt, unguarded honesty seemed to catch her off guard more than any careful diplomacy could have. She studied him a moment longer, then gestured toward the chapel's broken doorway, an invitation to speak somewhere at least nominally out of the wind.

They talked for the better part of an hour — Corwin describing, with a candor that surprised even him, the full extent of Maddox's control: the vanished treasury gold, the private army at Ashgrove, his own growing, still-unproven certainty that his father's death had been murder rather than illness, and Edran Thorne's execution as the deliberate removal of the one man who might have stopped it all before it went further. Cassia listened without interrupting, and when he finished, she told him, in turn, of her family's exile, of the emberhawks, of six thousand hired swords currently camped on his southern coast, and of a choice she had made before ever landing on Maren's shore: not to burn a kingdom she might instead be able to help save.

"I could still take the throne by force," she said, plainly, near the end. "I have the strength for it, and frankly, my bloodline's claim is older than your family's by three centuries. But I watched my own parents die in exile still believing a crown was worth more than the people beneath it, and I decided a long time ago I'd rather not make their mistake."

"Then what do you want instead?"

"An ally who actually rules his own kingdom, rather than a puppet wearing its crown. Help me remove the hand pulling your strings, Corwin Voss, and I promise you this: I have no interest in taking a throne from a king who's finally standing on his own."

It was not quite friendship, that afternoon in the ruined chapel — too much distrust remained on both sides for that word to fit honestly — but it was, unmistakably, the beginning of an alliance

neither Maddox nor the rest of the watching realm yet suspected existed.

Neither Corwin nor Cassia — nor the confident treasurer who still believed himself fully in control of events — yet understood that the true crisis bearing down on all of them had nothing to do with thrones at all, and was, even as they shook hands in that broken chapel, already breaking through an ancient gate six hundred miles to the north.



HOUSE THORNE

WE DO NOT BREAK



I.

While the capital braced itself for a war between a queen and a regent, the Greywall had spent four months already fighting a war no one south of the border believed was truly happening.

Lyra Thorne had buried herself in the watch's oldest records — brittle scrolls no one had unrolled in a century, written in a border dialect so archaic she'd needed Ser Osric's oldest surviving sergeant to help translate half the terminology — and what she found there had chilled her more thoroughly than any northern wind ever managed.

The Hollow Marchers were not simply dying and, in some inexplicable fashion, rising again, as the frightened patrol reports over the past two years had suggested. According to the oldest texts, they were being *called* — drawn together, organized, sung toward some ancient, patient purpose by something stirring for the first time in eight centuries beneath the deep ice of the Marches, a force the old border tongue named, always with a kind of ritual dread, the Unmade.

"There's a pattern to where the bodies keep appearing," she told Osric one evening, spreading four months of patrol maps across his worktable, red thread marking each incident in a slowly tightening spiral. "It's not random wandering. They're converging — every incident closer to the same point than the last." She tapped a spot on the map, deep in the Marches, marked on the old survey only as *the Sundered Gate*. "Here. An old gate everyone assumed was sealed for good, centuries back."

"Sealed how?" Osric asked, though something in his weathered face suggested he already half-suspected the answer wouldn't comfort him.

"I don't know yet. The texts are frustratingly vague about the how, and considerably more detailed about the why — which is worse, in some ways, because the why suggests the how matters a great deal less than we'd like."

II.

Kael arrived at the Greywall two days later, leading four hundred men — the largest force House Thorne could still muster without provoking Maddox's suspicion that they were preparing for war



against the crown itself, rather than for whatever quieter, colder purpose Lyra's letters had described only in careful, deliberately vague terms.

He had not come north because of Lyra's warnings about the Unmade, which had not yet reached him when he set out. He had come because four months of healing at Wintermoor, surrounded by his father's empty chair and his father's unfinished business, had left him with a restlessness he could no longer sit still against, and a growing, stubborn certainty that whatever war he actually needed to fight, it was not the political one still being waged in Duskhaven's courts and corridors.

Brother and sister had not seen each other since before their father's execution. There was little time, in the end, for the reunion either of them might once have imagined.

"You need to see this," Lyra said, within an hour of his arrival, and led him along the wall's parapet to a stretch of border where, for the first time in living memory, watchmen were reporting movement beyond the tree line at every single hour of the night — not the scattered, wandering Marchers of the old reports, but disciplined ranks of them, patient and silent, gathering and waiting in numbers no one on the wall had yet found the courage to count precisely.

Lyra had spent that same afternoon translating, with the help of Osric's oldest sergeant, a fragment of text so old its parchment had gone the color of weak tea, recovered from the very bottom of the watch's archive chest where it had evidently sat undisturbed for longer than anyone could say.

In the years before the wall was raised, the fragment read, in halting, archaic phrasing that Lyra had needed three full readings to untangle, there ruled beyond the ice a king who could not die, for he had traded his own death to something older than the ice itself in exchange for dominion over all who did. He was unmade in the trading — no longer a man, nor fully anything else — and he gathered to himself all who died beneath his gaze, binding them cold and patient to his purpose, until the first builders of Maren raised stone against him and sealed his gate with rites now lost, and believed, wrongly, that a wall alone could hold what only the old rites had actually bound.

"Rites now lost," Lyra repeated aloud, feeling something cold settle deeper in her chest than the evening wind alone could explain. "Osric — if the wall was never what actually held him back—"

"Then eight hundred years of border lords believing stone alone kept us safe," Osric finished grimly, "were wrong the entire time, and we've simply been fortunate no one tested the theory until now."

"How long has it looked like this?" Kael asked, watching pale shapes move at the edge of torchlight half a mile beyond the wall, with a stillness that unsettled him more than any charging cavalry ever had.

"Three nights. Getting worse each one." Lyra's voice was steady, but her hands, gripping the parapet stone, were not quite. "Osric's sent three ravens south in the last week alone. Not one reply."

That night, the old Sundered Gate broke.

III.

It did not shatter dramatically, in the end, the way the old ballads Lyra had grown up on always described such moments. It simply gave way — ancient stone, weakened by pressure that had clearly been building, unnoticed, for centuries, crumbling inward with a groan more felt through the ground than heard — and through the widening breach came the first true wave of the Unmade: not the mindless, shambling dead of frightened border folklore, but something considerably worse, moving with evident purpose and cold, disciplined intent, led by a tall, gaunt figure wreathed head to foot in a slow, blue-white fire that gave no heat and cast no warmth, whom the Greywall's oldest surviving watchman — an ancient, half-deaf veteran named Corren, weeping openly as he said it — named, in a voice cracking with a dread older than his own long memory, by a title out of half-forgotten nursery terrors: the Hollow King.

The wall held that night, but only barely, and only at a cost that left Osric's already-thin garrison bled to less than half its strength by the time the pale ranks finally withdrew before dawn, retreating not in defeat but with the unhurried patience of an army that understood it had all the time in the world, and intended to use every hour of it.

Lyra sent ravens south that same morning — to Duskhaven, to every noble house whose seat lay within reach of a fast enough bird, to anyone she could think of who might possibly still be listening to a name as thoroughly disgraced as Thorne — carrying a warning she already suspected, with a despair she did not have the luxury of indulging fully, would arrive too late to matter to a capital entirely consumed by its own far smaller war over a throne.

— IV. —

Corbin Hale was still alive to see the gate break, which he would later consider, in the exhausted, disbelieving days that followed, either the greatest fortune or the cruelest joke of his thirty years of service on the wall.

He had grown old enough in that service to have trained half the younger watchmen standing beside him that night, including a steady, quick-handed young man named Petyr who had once, years back, been the frightened seventeen-year-old crouching over a strange, unmarked corpse in the snow and asking questions no one in Duskhaven had ever bothered to answer. Petyr fought that night with a controlled ferocity that surprised even Corbin, cutting down three of the pale, silent ranks before a fourth nearly took his sword arm off at the shoulder, and it was Kael Thorne — arriving at exactly the right moment with a dozen Wintermoor spearmen at his back — who dragged the boy clear before the blow could land a second time.

"They don't feel fear," Corbin shouted to Kael over the low, terrible silence of the attack — no war cries from the enemy, no orders shouted between their ranks, only that patient, disciplined advance that unsettled the defenders more with every silent step than any screaming charge could have. "Watch their eyes, my lord. When the blue fire in them goes out, that's when they finally stay down. Not before."

Kael watched, and learned, and killed six of them himself before the pale ranks finally withdrew before dawn — not driven back by anything the garrison had done, he understood with a cold, sinking

certainty, but withdrawing simply because they had already gathered what information, or accomplished what purpose, that single testing assault had been meant to achieve.

Lyra found him afterward, sitting exhausted against the parapet stone with Corbin's borrowed cloak around his shoulders and old Corren's warning about the Hollow King still echoing in his ears.

"Four hundred men," he said quietly, "and I don't think we slowed them by more than an hour."

"Then we need more than four hundred men," Lyra said. "Which means someone in Duskhaven needs to finally start reading our letters."

— V. —

Not one raven received a reply that week, nor the week after. The realm's attention, as it had been for a year and more, remained fixed entirely on the wrong horizon.



HOUSE VOSS
STEADY THE REALM



I.

Vessa had not slept properly in weeks by the time she finally decided to speak.

It was not a single dramatic moment of conscience that moved her, in the end, but the slow accumulation of many small ones: the memory of Lord Thorne thanking her for a cup of wine; the sight of Kael Thorne's empty chair at council sessions he should by rights have attended as his father's heir; the increasingly strained, hollow look on King Corwin's face each time Maddox's hand settled on his shoulder in front of the court. She had spent a year telling herself that silence was simply the price of her mother's safety. She had begun, more recently, to suspect that silence was also, quietly and by degrees, costing her something she did not yet have a name for, but recognized, uneasily, as her own soul.

She went to the king directly, on a night she'd chosen carefully for the absence of Maddox's usual household spies, and told him everything: the vial, Aldous's instructions, the cup planted in Lord Thorne's chambers, the year of small reported conversations that had, she now understood with sick clarity, likely fed Maddox's schemes far more thoroughly than she'd ever let herself examine.

"Why tell me now," Corwin asked, when she'd finished, his voice carefully even despite the storm she could see building behind his eyes.

"Because I watched an honest man die for something I helped make possible," Vessa said, "and I've decided I would rather lose everything telling the truth than keep it by staying quiet a single week longer."

II.

Maddox was cornered three days later, dragged not from his own well-guarded chambers but from a hidden passage beneath the treasury archives — a passage, it would later emerge, he had used for years to move both coin and correspondence in and out of the palace unnoticed — by King Corwin's own household guard, acting on the king's direct and, for the first time in a year, entirely unshared order.



"You let them execute an innocent man," Corwin said, standing over the treasurer who had ruled him through fear disguised as counsel for the whole of his brief, unhappy reign. Vessa's confession sat sealed and witnessed in the king's own hand, and behind Corwin, arrayed along the walls of the treasury vault, stood guardsmen whose loyalty Vessa herself had helped him quietly verify over the preceding three days. "You poisoned my father, and blamed a man who never once lied to me in the whole of his life."

Maddox, cornered fully at last, offered no denial — only a calculation, delivered in the same smooth, unhurried voice he had used for every lie that came before it. "And you let me, Your Grace, because ruling through me was easier than ruling alone. Don't mistake this moment for innocence rediscovered. We built this rot together, you and I. I simply built the larger share of it."

It was, infuriatingly, not entirely false, and Corwin understood he would carry the truth of it for whatever remained of his reign — that his own passivity, his own year of comfortable, willful blindness, had been as necessary to Maddox's scheme as any poisoned cup.

He did not have long to sit with that particular reckoning. Within the hour, word reached the palace that Queen Cassia Vale's forces had broken camp on the southern coast and begun their march toward the capital, emberhawks visible even at that distance, circling low and slow above a column of six thousand soldiers moving with the unhurried confidence of an army that expected, very shortly, to be welcomed rather than resisted.

III.

The city gates opened not to a conqueror, in the end, but to an arranged and carefully staged arrival — Cassia Vale riding at the head of her column with Ashwing wheeling overhead, met at the outer gate by King Corwin himself, bareheaded and without his crown, in a gesture both of them had agreed upon in advance, in a second, briefer meeting at the ruined river chapel, as the clearest possible signal to a watching, uncertain city that whatever was about to happen inside those walls, it would not be another war fought over their heads.

The smallfolk who gathered along the processional road to watch — the same road Edran Thorne had ridden down, wide-eyed at its poverty, less than a year before — did not entirely understand what they were witnessing, but they understood enough: that the fat, hated tax collectors in green sashes had not been seen in the streets for three days; that the treasurer whose face had adorned half the city's fear for a year now sat in chains in the palace's own dungeon; that a foreign queen with living fire-birds had ridden into their city and had not, as of yet, burned a single building to the ground.

Hope, in Duskhaven that autumn afternoon, was a fragile and unfamiliar thing, but it was, unmistakably, present.

Maddox's public trial was set for the following week — Corwin insisted on a trial, however brief, both because it was the right thing to do and because he understood, with a clarity that surprised even himself, that a kingdom built on the same swift, convenient justice that had killed Edran Thorne deserved no better fate than the one it had already suffered. It was a small thing, that insistence on due process, but it was the first genuinely kingly decision Corwin Voss had made entirely on his own

authority, and Cassia, watching him make it, found her earlier instinct in the harbor at Tessara — that this frightened young man might prove a genuine ally rather than merely a convenient one — settling, for the first time, into something closer to actual respect.

— IV. —

The raven that finally broke through the capital's cautious, celebratory chaos arrived on the fourth afternoon after Cassia's arrival, so travel-worn and rain-soaked that the words on the parchment had nearly bled away entirely by the time a palace steward, recognizing the twice-twisted Thorne seal beneath the damage, thought to bring it directly to the king rather than filing it, as so many identical letters had been filed and ignored, in some forgotten archive drawer.

Corwin read it standing on the palace's outer balcony, with Cassia beside him and the newly liberated city spread out below them in the last gold light of afternoon, and felt something shift inside his chest that had nothing to do with either the war he had just survived or the fragile new alliance he had just built.

The Greywall has fallen to a testing assault we barely survived, Lyra Thorne's hand read, blurred but legible enough, and I do not believe it will hold against what comes next. The dead do not stay dead in the Hollow Marches, Your Grace, and they are no longer wandering — they are marching, under a captain the old texts name the Hollow King, and I do not believe there is a single soul left in Duskhaven who still thinks this a border superstition rather than what it actually is: a warning, sent for a year and ignored for just as long, that whatever war you believe you are fighting for that throne will not matter at all to the army now coming south to take it from all of us equally.

Corwin read it once, then a second time, then handed it wordlessly to Cassia, who read it with the particular, focused stillness of a woman recalculating, in real time, every plan she had made since first setting foot on Maren's shore.

"Thorne," she said finally. "Edran Thorne's children."

"His daughter," Corwin said. "And, I think, from the hand at the bottom, his son as well. Both of them at the Greywall, apparently, doing the one thing this entire kingdom should have been doing for the past two years instead of murdering honest men over a treasury ledger."

— V. —

He sent for Cassia Vale's full council that same evening, and for the first time since his coronation, King Corwin Voss convened a war table at which every voice present was one he had genuinely chosen to trust, rather than one Maddox had arranged to surround him with.

"I want the northern road opened within the week," he said, once Lyra's letter had been read aloud in full, and its contents had settled, heavy and undeniable, over the assembled council. "Whatever men we can spare from the southern garrisons, whatever grain and steel the treasury — Maddox's treasury, God help us, finally put to some honest use — can supply."

"You'd send aid," Cassia said, "to House Thorne. The family your own treasurer executed the head of, not a year past."

"I'd send aid," Corwin corrected, "to the only people in this entire kingdom who tried, for two years, to warn the rest of us about something that turns out to have been considerably more important than the throne we were all so busy fighting over. It's the very least this crown owes them, and it happens also to be, I suspect, the only decision left that might actually save all our lives."

Cassia studied him for a long moment across the war table — this young king who had spent a year as someone else's puppet and had, in the space of a single terrible week, begun, however unsteadily, to become something else entirely — and found herself, for the first time since landing on Maren's shore, genuinely uncertain which of them, in the end, was going to prove the more important ally in whatever came next.

"Then we ride north together," she said. "My hawks, your soldiers, and whatever remains of House Thorne's stubborn honesty, all pointed at the same horizon for once, instead of at each other."

Whether an exiled queen's fire and a boy-king's newly steadied resolve, joined at last to four hundred exhausted watchmen and two grieving, resourceful Thorne children, would prove enough to hold back whatever patient, ancient purpose was gathering beyond the broken Sundered Gate — that remained, as the sun set blood-red over a capital that had only just begun to understand which war it was actually fighting, entirely unwritten.

— VI. —

In Wintermoor's abandoned solar, where a sixteen-year-old girl had once sat curled into a window seat reading old border histories twice over while her father lived and her family remained whole, the window seat sat empty now, dust gathering faintly on a book of borderland history that had, in the end, turned out to matter rather more than anyone in that quiet, peaceful autumn had believed possible.

Six hundred miles north, on the Greywall's battered parapet, Lyra Thorne stood beside her brother in the gathering dark, watching the tree line where pale, patient shapes had begun, once again, to gather, and did not yet know that help, at long last, was riding toward them.

She knew only that the night was coming, and that whatever else her family had lost in the year since her father's death — a home, a reputation, a peace she suspected none of them would ever fully recover — they had not lost the one thing Edran Thorne had spent his whole life teaching his children to hold onto harder than any of it.

They had not lost the truth. And for the first time in a year, however faintly, it was finally beginning to travel faster than the lies that had buried it.

END OF PART ONE

What happens when the queen's fire and the king's soldiers finally reach the Greywall — and what truly waits behind the Hollow King's cold blue flame — is a story for Part Two.

APPENDIX: THE WORLD OF MAREN

The Realm

Maren is a single great continent, divided at the time of this telling into seven provinces bound loosely under the Iron Throne of Duskhaven. The throne has passed through two dynasties in living memory: the ancient Rhoswyn line, which ruled for three centuries before being overthrown, and the Voss line, which has held it for three generations since.

Duskhaven — The capital, seat of the Iron Court, and the largest city in Maren, built where three rivers meet the sea. Its palace towers have grown no less grand in recent years, even as the city beneath them has grown considerably poorer.

Wintermoor — Seat of House Thorne, in the far north of the realm, sworn for eleven generations to hold the northern march and guard the Greywall.

The Greywall — An ancient fortification, eight hundred feet high in places, stretching the width of the continent's northern border. Built, according to the oldest surviving border texts, not merely as a wall but as part of an older binding whose full nature has long since been forgotten by everyone except the dwindling watch who still, however thinly, maintain it.

The Hollow Marches — The frozen, largely uninhabited country beyond the Greywall, home only to scattered clans of Marchers — and, it now seems, to something considerably older and less forgiving than either.

Tessara — A free port city across the Narrow Sea, home to House Vale's long exile and to a great deal of the continent's less official trade.

Ashgrove — A hunting lodge belonging to House Maddox for two generations, quietly repurposed, in the years before this story begins, into a private, unofficial garrison.

The Great Houses

House Voss — Rulers of the Iron Throne. Sigil: a black crown on crimson. Words: *Steady the Realm*.

House Thorne — Lords of Wintermoor and wardens of the northern march for eleven generations. Sigil: a gray wolf's head on white. Words: *We Do Not Break*.

House Maddox — Holders of the crown's treasury, and until recently, considerable unofficial

power besides. Sigil: a coiled silver serpent on green.

House Vale, formerly the royal Rhoswyn dynasty — Exiled heirs of the old throne, returned at last from across the Narrow Sea. Sigil: a burning hawk on black.

A Note on the Unmade

The being that the oldest border texts name the Hollow King, and the risen dead who march beneath him, are referred to collectively in the old border tongue as the Unmade — not dead, precisely, nor properly alive, but something unmade from both states and bound, however imperfectly, to a will far older than the wall first raised to contain it. Little else about their nature is known with any confidence: a gap in the realm's knowledge that mattered a great deal more, in the year this story tells, than anyone still living had reason to expect.

The story of House Thorne, House Vale, and the Iron Throne continues in Book Two: The Hollow King.

BOOK ONE OF THE EMBER THRONE SAGA



THE CROWN OF EMBERS

King Aldric Voss is dying, and the kingdom of Maren is already beginning to fracture. Behind the throne, Lord Halden Maddox holds the realm in his grip while the young King Corwin struggles to discover who he can trust.

When the honorable Lord Edran Thorne is condemned for a murder he did not commit, his family is scattered—and his daughter Lyra begins to understand that survival will require more than grief. Far across the Narrow Sea, the exiled Queen Cassia Vale returns with soldiers, gold, and three legendary emberhawks, but not simply to reclaim a throne.

As enemies become possible allies and old loyalties are tested, a darker danger rises beyond the Greywall. Ancient records speak of the Unmade, a force stirring beneath the deep ice and drawing the Hollow Marchers toward a long-sealed gate.

The struggle for Maren has begun. But the war for the throne may be only the beginning.



A NOVEL

JANVI THAKRE